

» MATCH OF THE
FORTNIGHT

Sorry state of affairs: Goncalo Guedes (left) of Villarreal scores his team's third goal against Barcelona, whose chances of defending its La Liga title look increasingly bleak this season. GETTYIMAGES

FALL OF THE GIANT

Barcelona's season took another **devastating hit** with a humbling loss at home against Villarreal.

BARCELONA

3

Gundogan 60'
Pedri 68'
Bailly(og) 71'

VILLARREAL

5

G. Moreno 41'
Akhomach 54'
Guedes 84'
Sorloth 90+9'
Morales 90+12'

The era of inexperienced managers taking over the reign at their former clubs found its latest casualty with Xavi Hernandez announcing his departure from FC Barcelona at the end of the season. The club's chances of defending its La Liga title look increasingly bleak, tottering at third position in La Liga, 10 points behind Real Madrid, and having also exited the Supercopa de Espana and the Copa del Rey in a matter of weeks.

The rut continued as the team succumbed to a 3-5 home loss to Villarreal at the Lluís Companys Olympic Stadium on January 27, enduring **its third loss in five matches.**

It was Barcelona that came closest to opening the scoring in the first quarter, with Villarreal needing Phillip Jorgensen to be at full stretch to palm Joao Felix's deflected shot over the bar.

Gerard Moreno thought he had given the Yellow Submarine the lead in the 22nd minute, but his goal was ruled offside after his strike

partner Alexander Sorloth was adjudged to have interfered with play by blocking Ronald Araujo.

The pair wasn't going to be denied the next time, though. Sorloth's pass from the left wing following a throw-in found Moreno, who rifled a first-time shot into the net.

A mistake from substitute Joao Cancelo gifted the visitor its second, with former La Masia player Ilias Akhomach putting the chance away.

Barca clawed its way back into the contest with two goals in eight minutes — a couple of accurate finishes from inside the box from midfielders Ilkay Gundogan and Pedri.

The comeback seemed complete when Eric Bailly bundled in a freekick into his net in the 71st minute.

But Goncalo Guedes brought Villarreal back level, putting the finishing touch on a swift counterattack in the 84th minute. Barca was ultimately undone after a rush of blood from Araujo in the ninth minute of stoppage time — gifting the ball to Etienne Capoue inside the penalty box — helped Sorloth complete a tap-in and put his team ahead. Jose Luis Morales added a fifth in the 102nd minute following another counter, settling the result.